

WE ARE ALL KURT RUSSELL

In director John Carpenter's 1982 horror film, *The Thing*, the crew of an isolated Antarctic research base, led by a never-hotter Kurt Russell, is attacked by a shapeshifting alien. The monster can look like anyone, so instead of working together to defeat it, the snow-trapped crew turns on each other. This is what the monster wants.

Money is the alien. We are all Kurt Russell.

Money is purposefully disorienting and confusing. Everyone's journey with it is personal. There's no such thing as advice everyone should take, and every piece of advice works differently for every person's lifestyle and circumstances. The only mistake you've made is maybe you believed this was an isolating problem that said something about your character and intelligence. It isn't, and it doesn't.

The reason I'm so dedicated to sharing all my money ugliness is that we need to end the fallacy that we can't, or shouldn't, talk about money. I used to be absolutely terrified of frankly and openly discussing money. I took that fear, and I made thinking about and researching and speaking out about money into my full-time job. I know more than I did when I intentionally avoided anything financial, but—after hours and days and months and years of looking into every aspect of this stuff—I still don't know everything. Honestly, I barely know enough.

The system is a winding labyrinth of paperwork and jargon and debt and dead-ends. I'm much more aware, but I'm far from an expert.

You don't have to be an expert. Hardly anyone is. But you *do* have to pay attention. It sucks. It super sucks. I know it sucks. But unfortunately you can't opt out of dealing with money, and in the past few years, I've opened my eyes to my own financial reality, and as a result my financial *feelings*, if not my actual situation, *have* gotten better.